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# Developing local grammars of speech acts in Italian: The case of apology

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**Abstract**

This study explores the viability of applying the local grammar approach to speech act studies beyond English by developing a local grammar of apology in Italian. Drawing on data taken from the spoken Italian corpus of KIPTO, we identified nine functional terms that are commonly associated with the semantics of apologies in Italian. We subsequently used these terms to analyse instances of apologies from a local grammar perspective, leading to the identification of 18 local grammar patterns of apology, with the pattern "Forgiveness-seeking" being the most prominent one. We further discussed the opportunities (e.g., facilitating cross-linguistic speech act studies) and challenges (e.g., corpus availability, identification of speech act instances in corpora) of using the local grammar approach to account for speech acts in languages other than English. Overall, our argument is, and our study shows, that local grammars can be a viable approach to speech act studies in and across various languages.
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*Keywords:* Speech acts; Local grammars; Apology in Italian; Spoken Italian

## 1. INTRODUCTION

This study develops a local grammar of apology in Italian, aiming to further explore the feasibility of applying the local grammar approach to account for speech act realisations in languages other than English. Simply put, local grammar is an approach to linguistic analysis that seeks to describe language use associated with one specific meaning or function (Hunston, 2002: 178). It has been applied to account for various speech acts such as request (Su, 2017), apology (Su and Wei, 2018), and disclaiming (Cheng and Ching, 2018). Overall, these studies have shown that local grammars are particularly useful for describing the lexicogrammatical realisations of pragmatic functions or, more specifically, speech

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acts (see Section 3 for more discussion). However, except for one attempt that has recently been made to develop local grammars of speech acts in Chinese (Su and Fu, 2023), existing studies have unexceptionally applied local grammars to account for speech act realisations in English. As the primary function of language is to communicate and as such speech acts are likely to exist in all languages, even if with considerable cross-linguistic variation, this raises the question as to whether the local grammar approach can also be used to account for speech acts in other languages. In this paper we address this question by taking apology in Italian as a starting point, with the overarching goal to explore the viability and value of the local grammar approach to speech act studies in and across various languages.

## 2. STUDIES ON APOLOGY IN ITALIAN

Drawing on insights from previous research (Aijmer, 1996; Bella, 2014; Su and Wei, 2018), the present study defines apology as a speech act which is performed to restore social equilibrium and harmony. This broad definition encompasses a wide range of cases, including those that Lakoff (2001: 203–204) refers to as "apparent apology", i.e., apologies that frame an utterance likely to be offensive. Therefore, the study examines patterns that express the need to restore social harmony and manage "rapport" with others (Spencer-Oatey, 2008), either by expressing regret for a past misbehaviour or by attempting to prevent actions that may be face-threatening or violate sociocultural norms, i.e., corrective and preventive apology in Shevcenko and Goturov's (2019: 318–319) terms.

The concept of apology has been closely linked to that of politeness (Brown and Levinson, 1987), as apologising can be seen as a means to save face for the hearer and simultaneously threaten the face of the speaker (Olshtain, 1989, 121; Ogiermann, 2009). And as a politeness-sensitive speech act, apology has been extensively examined in English (Fraser, 1981; Goffman, 1971; Grainger and Harris, 2007; Drew et al., 2016; Heritage and Raymond, 2016; Aijmer, 2019; Heritage et al., 2019). However, apology in other languages, such as Italian, has received relatively less attention (Businaro, 2002; De Marco and Paone, 2022; Demir and Takkac, 2016; Lipson, 1994; Nuzzo, 2007; Trubnikova, 2017; Walker, 2017; Ghezzi and Molinelli, 2019). Except for Businaro (2002) and Ghezzi and Molinelli (2019) which focused on apology in L1 Italian, the other studies can be roughly categorised as either cross-linguistic pragmatic studies (Lipson, 1994; Demir and Takkac, 2016) or interlanguage pragmatic studies (Nuzzo, 2007; Trubnikova, 2017; Walker, 2017), as summarised in Table 1.

As can be seen in Table 1, previous research has predominantly employed a contrastive pragmatic approach to examine apologies in Italian. For instance, Lipson (1994) conducted a contrastive investigation into apology strategies used in American English and Italian. By analysing apologies extracted from American sitcoms and their Italian translations by Italian L1 speakers, Lipson (1994) observed that Italian apologies primarily employ the strategy of 'asking forgiveness', which is a subformula of Owen's (1983) Priming Remedial Move Strategy of 'requesting restoration of balance', while other strategies such as 'expressing attitude towards offence' are less prominent.

Nuzzo (2007), using data collected via role play and an interlanguage corpus, identified eight strategies (e.g., *expression of regret, request for forgiveness, confession of fault, justification*) for making apologies in Italian. Similarly, Trubnikova (2017) used data gathered from Discourse Completion Task (DCT) and role-play exercises to investigate the differences between apology strategies used by Italian and Russian L1 speakers, as well as interlanguage apologies of Russians using Italian as their second language. Her study identified the source of pragmatic failure in the use of apologies by Russian learners of Italian, which has implications for Italian L2 learners in speech act learning. It is worth noting that the above-mentioned studies reveal Italian L1 speakers' strong preference for the strategy of requesting forgiveness, which has not been fully mastered by Italian L2 learners (see also Nuzzo, 2007; Trubnikova, 2017).

The studies discussed above provide valuable insights into apologies in Italian; however, they have not yet attempted to offer a functional-grammatical description of how apologies are realised in the language. To bridge this gap, the present study adopts the recently emerging local grammar approach to account for the speech act of apology in Italian. Briefly, local grammar represents a functional-grammatical approach which uses context-specific terms to analyse linguistic forms with regard to their pragmatic functions in the specific context of the chosen meaning or function, i.e., speech act in the present study (see Section 3 for more discussion). The advantage, as compared with the traditional grammatical analysis, is that the kind of functional-grammatical descriptions offered by local grammar is "more simple, more precise, and more useful" (Hunston and Sinclair, 2000: 101), as has been shown in previous studies on local grammars of speech acts in English (e.g., Su, 2017; Su and Wei, 2018; Zhang and Su, 2022). Such a functional-grammatical description can facilitate the establishment of a linguistic repertoire for performing the target speech act and could thus meet the pedagogical needs in teaching speech acts in L2 context. Furthermore, it is also hoped that the attempt to develop a local grammar of apology in Italian will not only inspire future research into other speech acts in Italian, but also speech acts in other languages, thereby providing a potentially valuable approach to speech act studies in general.

Table 1
Studies on the speech act of apology in Italian.

| Study | Data | Theoretical framework | Research scope |
|---|---|---|---|
| Lipson (1994) | Apology scenes retrieved from American sitcoms and their transcribed versions rewritten by Italian L1 speakers. | Marion Owen's remedial strategies (Owen, 1983) and Olshtain and Cohen's semantic formulas in the apology speech act set (Olshtain and Cohen, 1983). | Cross-linguistic comparison; |
| Businaro (2002) | Dialogues retrieved from radio, television broadcasting, telephone calls, and the Italian spoken corpus of Lessico di frequenza dell'Italiano Parlato (LIP). | Speech act theory (Searle, 1969); conversation analysis; politeness theories (Goody, 1978). | Apology in Italian L1 |
| Nuzzo (2007) | Dialogues elicited by role play, involving Italian learners and Italian L1 speakers. | Categorisation based on (Blum-Kulka et al., 1989), Trosborg (1995), Márquez Reiter (2000)'s intercultural studies of apology. | Interlanguage analysis; Cross-linguistic comparison; |
| Demir and Takkac (2016) | Apology instances retrieved from COCA (Corpus of Contemporary American English); CLIPS (Corpora e Lessici dell'Italiano Parlato e Scritto), PAISÀ (Piattaforma per l'Apprendimento dell'Italiano Su corpora Annotati), and BADIP (BAnca Dati dello Italiano Parlato). | Marion Owen's remedial strategies (Owen, 1983) and Olshtain and Cohen's semantic formulas in the apology speech act set (Olshtain and Cohen, 1983). | Cross-linguistic comparison |
| Trubnikova (2017) | Dialogues elicited by Discourse Completion Task (DCT), involving Italian L1 speakers, Russian L1 speakers, and Russian speakers using L2 Italian. | Requests and Apologies: Cross-cultural Speech Act Realisation Patterns (CCSARP) proposed by Blum-Kulka et al. (1989). | Interlanguage analysis; cross-linguistic comparison |
| Walker (2017) | Email responses of Australian learners of L2 Italian elicited by DCT. | Brown and Levinson's Politeness Theory (Brown and Levinson, 1987). | Interlanguage analysis |
| Ghezzi and Molinelli (2019) | Selected Italian comedies written during the 18th and the 21st century. | Categorization of apologies containing a form derived from the lemma scus- in four subclasses: politeness, mixed messages, mock politeness, and impoliteness. | Diachronic analysis of apology in Italian L1. |

Furthermore, despite the increasing awareness of the significance of authentic data in corpus-pragmatic research (Aijmer, 1996; Weisser, 2003; Adolphs, 2008), there have been very few studies that have examined Italian apologies in naturally-occurring data. As indicated in Table 1, existing studies on apologies in Italian have tended to use an experimental approach to elicit instances of apologies by using methods such as role play (Nuzzo, 2007), Discourse Completion Tasks (Trubnikova, 2017; Walker, 2017), or by examining apologies in scripted conversation (Lipson, 1994; Ghezzi and Molinelli, 2019). Although elicited data may serve their research purposes well, it is also necessary to investigate apologies in Italian in naturally occurring texts. A few exceptions recognising the importance of authentic data are Demir and Takkac (2016) which examined apology instances in Italian corpora (CLIPS, PAISÀ, BADIP), and Businaro (2002) which investigated the distribution of apology strategies by drawing on data taken from the LIP corpus.

To sum up, it seems that no attempt has yet been made to adequately document and describe the linguistic realisations of Italian apologies by drawing on naturally occurring data. Therefore, in the present study, we attempt to bridge this gap by adopting the local grammar approach to systematically account for the realisations of apologies in Italian (Section 4). Our overarching goal is to further explore the value of local grammars in accounting for speech act realisations in various languages and the implications for speech act studies in general.

## 3. LOCAL GRAMMARS AND SPEECH ACT STUDIES

As mentioned in the introduction of this paper, local grammar is an alternative approach to linguistic analysis and description. Unlike general grammars, each local grammar seeks to account for a subset of language use that is associated with one specific meaning or function (Hunston, 2002: 178), with meaning or function used here roughly as an equivalent to speech acts (e.g., request, apology). Previous studies have comprehensively discussed the features that distinguish local grammars from general or traditional grammar, emphasising in particular that local grammars use context-specific functional terminologies to analyse corresponding syntactic units, as illustrated in Tables 2a and 2b.

Table 2a
General grammar analysis.

| Subject | Predicate | Complement |
|---|---|---|
| *I* | *apologise* | *for my earlier outburst* |
| *I* | *regret* | *not saying yes when you asked me to marry you* |

Table 2b
The alternative local grammar analysis (Su and Wei, 2018: 449).

| Apologiser | Apologising | Specification |
|---|---|---|
| *I* | *apologise* | *for my earlier outburst* |
| *I* | *regret* | *not saying yes when you asked me to marry you* |

The analyses presented in Tables 2a and 2b clearly show that general grammar analysis, though certainly valuable, does not provide insights into the discourse function of the utterances as making apologies, whereas the alternative local grammar analysis, taking into consideration the context and using functional terminologies such as Apologiser, Apologising and Specification, can more easily reveal the discourse function of the utterances as apology-making. The implication here is that, as Bondi (2022): 53 notes, "[t]he exploration of context with a view to lexico-grammatical patterns and combinations of meanings also allows *the study of local grammar* (context-specific terminologies meant to analyze specific pragmatic or discourse acts)" (italics added). It is in this respect that it has been argued that local grammars are particularly useful in accounting for pragmatic or speech acts (Su and Wei, 2018), which has also been convincingly demonstrated in many previous studies, as discussed below. In addition, Tables 2a and 2b also suggests that local grammars can be placed at the interface of different levels: lexico-grammar, semantics and pragmatics. The kind of local grammar terminologies correspond to semantic roles that on the one hand manifest the valency frame of a verb, and on the other hand point to the speech act type with its pragmatic configuration. Starting from specific meanings or functions, local grammars identify semantic roles and look at their different combinations with regard to the lexico-grammar of a specific language. From this point of view, they seem to have great potential for cross-cultural analysis (see Su and Lu, 2023).

At this point, readers familiar with construction grammar may wonder to what extent is local grammar similar to or different from construction grammar. It must be said that the two are quite different at least in the following two aspects (**see also** Hunston and Su (2019) for more discussion). In terms of definition, local grammar seeks to describe the lexicogrammatical realisations associated with one particular meaning or function, whereas construction grammar is concerned with form-meaning pairings and the mental representation of this kind of pairing. In terms of analysis, local grammar uses context-specific terminologies (i.e., terms proposed within the context of a given meaning/function) to analyse corresponding syntactic units, whereas construction grammar uses thematic roles such as Agent, Recipient etc, to analyse instances of constructions in general context. Hence, terminologies used in local grammar analysis are highly transparent yet relatively less generalisable (i.e., local grammar terminologies proposed for a given speech act may only be applicable to that specific speech act); in contrast, thematic roles in construction grammar analysis are highly generalisable yet relatively less transparent. Despite the differences, the two are also to some extent associated, in particular that the kind of local grammar patterns can arguably be interpreted as constructions, which has been comprehensively discussed in Su and Wei (2023). In other words, we can interpret the patterns identified in the present study and the linguistic forms associated with each as 'form-meaning' pairings or, more specifically, constructions. For example, linguistic forms associated with the pattern Apologising + Specification include *sorry for/about/that* . . ., and this kind of form-meaning pairing between *sorry for/about/that* . . . and Apologising + Specification can be interpreted as 'specifying the reason of an apology' construction.

Currently, local grammars have been employed to account for several pragmatic or speech acts in English. For instance, Barnbrook (2002) examined definition in dictionaries and developed a local grammar of definition. Cheng and Ching (2018) analysed the legal statements of disclaimers in company reports and established a local grammar of disclaiming. Moreover, using a corpus compiled of scripts of the sitcom *The Big Bang Theory*, Su (2017) and Su and Wei (2018) examined the lexicogrammatical realisations of requests and apologies respectively, which in turn led to a local grammar of request and that of apology. In addition, a few studies also extended the local grammar approach to account for discourse functions in academic contexts. For example, Su and Zhang (2020) developed a local grammar of exemplification and Zhang and Su (2022) a local grammar of definition in Linguistics research articles. Overall, these studies demonstrate that local grammar can be an effective method for advancing speech act studies,

in particular in that it enables researchers to systematically document and describe the linguistic realisations of a given pragmatic or speech act.

However, it should be noted that, with one exception which attempted to develop local grammars of speech acts in Chinese (Su and Fu, 2023), local grammars to date have primarily been applied to account for speech acts in English, which inevitably raises the question as to whether local grammars could also be applied to the study of speech acts in other languages. This study addresses this question by seeking to develop a local grammar of apology in Italian. Our aim, as has been noted earlier, is to explore the feasibility and applicability of local grammars in multilingual, cross-linguistic and cross-cultural speech act studies.

## 4. TOWARDS A LOCAL GRAMMAR OF APOLOGY IN ITALIAN

### *4.1. Corpus and data retrieval*

This study uses the KIPTO corpus, which is a combination of the KIP subcorpus and the ParlaTo subcorpus. The KIP subcorpus includes around 70 hours of recorded speech collected in Turin and Bologna from university students and professors between 2016 and 2019, while the ParlaTO subcorpus contains 60 hours of spontaneous speech collected in Turin from speakers of varying social status between 2018 and 2019 (Mauri et al., 2019; Cerruti and Ballarè, 2020: 173–74; Cerruti and Ballarè, 2020; Cerruti, 2021). Both subcorpora are part of the KIParla corpus, an open-access corpus of spoken Italian that is available on the NoSketch Engine interface. The KIPTO corpus is a monitoring corpus and, as of May 2022 (the time when we started the present study), contained 922,477 tokens. The types of conversations in the KIP subcorpus include spontaneous conversation, exams, interviews, lessons, and office hours (Mauri et al., 2019), while the ParlaTO subcorpus includes semi-structured interviews (Cerruti and Ballarè, 2020). Despite the relatively small corpus size, it has to be noted that the KIPTO corpus is currently the largest spoken corpus of Italian available to the public and can provide valuable data that reflect the use of modern Italian.

The data retrieval followed two main procedures: 1) identifying lexical markers used for expressing apologies in Italian, which could then be used to retrieve potential instances of apology in the KIPTO corpus; and 2) manually filtering out those instances which were not real apologies, which was done when we perform the local grammar analysis. Details of these procedures are discussed below.

Like apologies in English, realisations of apologies in Italian are highly routinised and conventionalised. For example, various forms derived from the lemma *scus-* 'excus-' are perceived by Italian speakers as a prototypical realisation of the speech act of apology (Ghezzi and Molinelli, 2019). Therefore, it is possible to retrieve instances of Italian apologies from a corpus by searching a set of such conventionalised forms or illocutionary force indicating devices (IFIDs) (Levinson, 1983: 238). Bearing in mind the principle of total accountability (Leech, 1992: 112), which presupposes that the analyst should avoid conscious selection of data which may distort the results, we went through the following steps to systematically identify IFIDs or apology markers in Italian.

(A) Drawing on insights from previous studies of apology in Italian (Lipson, 1994; Businaro, 2002; Demir and Takkac, 2016; Trubnikova, 2017; Walker, 2017), we compiled a list of markers that were mentioned in existing studies.
(B) We leveraged the GPT-4 language model accessible on the Bing chatbot (now called Copilot) to provide a list of lexical markers for apology in Italian using the strategy of few-shot prompting, i.e., providing a prompt[3] with examples of apology markers already identified. The GPT-4 model was chosen for its proficiency in recognising pragmatic elements of apologies (Yu et al., in press 2024). The prompt and one example of the resulting outputs generated by the Bing chatbot are presented in Appendix 1.
(C) We conducted interviews and discussions with two Italian L1 speakers, including one of the authors of this paper, asked the two interviewees to list expressions for corrective and preventive apologies and then checked the previous preliminary list obtained through A and B.
(D) Doing so allowed us to identify a set of apology markers and their variants, which were then searched for in the KIPTO corpus to retrieve instances of the specific markers. A few of the lexical markers (e.g., *scusarsi*, *perdono*, *dispiacersi*) identified through A, B and C above were excluded because searching these markers returned no hit in the KIPTO corpus. The absence of these markers may either be attributed to the relatively small corpus size or the specific situational types included in the corpus. Accordingly, Table 3 only presents the markers found in the corpus.

[3] A prompt, in the context of interacting with AI or machine learning models like GPT-3 or GPT-4, refers to the input or instruction provided to the model to generate a response or perform a task. It's the information or query given to the AI system to guide it in producing the desired output.

Table 3
Apology markers in Italian and their frequency in the KIPTO corpus.

| Item | Meaning | Variant | Frequency |
|---|---|---|---|
| *scusare* | to excuse | *scusa, scusami, scusi, mi scusi, scusate, scusatemi* | 436 |
| *dispiacere* | to upset | *mi dispiace* | 22 |
| *spiacere* | to upset | *mi spiace* | 14 |
| *Scusa* | excuse (noun) | *chiedo scusa* | 6 |
| *perdonare* | to pardon (verb) | *perdonami, mi perdoni, perdonatemi* | 4 |
| *colpa* | guilt | *mi sento in colpa* | 1 |
| **Total** | | | **483** |

At this point, it should be mentioned that highly conventionalised constructions may show a discrepancy between form and function or, in other words, IFIDs that conventionally indicate the speech act of apology may have other pragmatic functions such as *discourse-binding* and *attention-getting*. This points to the need to carefully check the co-text of each instance through concordance analysis, a corpus linguistics tool which allows the analyst to be aware of the context (Baker et al., 2008), so as to make sure that all the analysed instances are real apologies. The concordance analysis was done in the subsequent local grammar analyses. That is, we examined the expanded co-text of each instance we retrieved and only performed local grammar analyses of those instances which count as genuine apologies, including both expressions of corrective apology, expressing regret for a past misbehaviour, and expressions of preventive apology, mitigating face-threatening acts. Ambiguous cases were further discussed among the authors. Table 3 presents the frequency of the instances where the respective lexical marker was used to express real apology. Types of instances that were excluded from the local grammar analyses were, for example, apology used in indirect speech, *scusa* used as a noun with the meaning of 'excuse', *mi dispiace* used to express dislike or feelings of condolence.

### *4.2. Local grammar analyses of apology in Italian*

One fundamental task of doing local grammar analysis is the identification of functional elements that may characterise the components of speech act realisations. Basically, the identification of functional elements is based on deconstructing the semantic relations between each syntactic unit which has a pragmatic meaning. Drawing on insights from the local grammar of apology developed in English (Su and Wei, 2018) and based on our preliminary analyses, we identified nine functional elements that were found useful for analysing apologies in Italian. These functional elements are listed and illustrated in Table 4.

Table 4
Terms for a local grammar analysis of apology in Italian [adapted from Su and Wei, 2018].

| Term | Explanation | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Forgiveness-seeking | The act of seeking forgiveness | ***Scusa**mi.*<br>'**Excuse** me.' |
| Apologising | The act of expressing regret | *Mi **dispiace**.*<br>'To me **it upsets**' |
| Apologiser | The one who apologises | ***Mi** dispiace.*<br>'**To me** it upsets' |
| Apologisee | (a) to whom the apology is made<br>(b) from whom the apologiser seeks forgiveness | *Mi scusi **professore.***<br>'Pardon me, **professor**.' |
| Specification | The elements that specify the offence / reason for an apology or for forgiveness-seeking | *Scusa, **anch'io ti ho disturbato**.*<br>'Excuse me, **I also have disturbed you**.' |
| Intensifier | The elements that upgrade the degree of regret or the sincerity of the request for forgiveness | *Scusami **tanto**.*<br>'Excuse me **very much**.' |
| Initiator | The elements indicating that an apology is going to be made | ***Ma** scusa.*<br>'**But** excuse me.' |
| Morphological Apologiser | The apologisers that are morphologically expressed | *Chied**-o** scusa.*<br>'**I** ask forgiveness.' |
| Morphological Apologisee | The apologisees that are morphologically expressed | *Scus**-a.***<br>'**You** excuse'. |

Bearing in mind the differences between Italian and English, two major issues were considered when mapping local grammar terminologies onto formal elements in Italian. The first consideration is related to the choice between the term 'Apologising' and the term 'Regret-expressing'. Previous studies on apologies in Italian have preferred to use the explicit term 'Regret-expressing' (e.g., Trubnikova, 2017) instead of "Apologising", which is often perceived as a typical English expression. Although the meaning of *apologise* is not explicit, by definition it refers to the act to "express regret for something done or said".[4] Therefore, in this study, we adopted the term 'Apologising' to align more closely with the local grammar of apology developed in English, which would thus also help to uncover the cross-linguistic differences between apologies in Italian and in English from a local grammar perspective (see subsection 4.4). In the discussion of the analyses and the results, nevertheless, the two terms were used interchangeably.

The second issue is related to the morphosyntactic rules that characterise the Italian language, where the grammatical category of person can normally be encoded in the inflectional morpheme of a conjugated verb. Italian often omits the overt expression of the subject of a verb. For example, in the expression of *scusa* 'you excuse', a second-person imperative form of the verb *scusare* "excuse", the presence of the apologisee is indicated by the morpheme *-a*. In the expression of *chiedo scusa* 'I ask forgiveness', the presence of apologiser is indicated by the morpheme *-o*. However, it appears that the subjects expressed through morphemes are pragmatically different from those expressed through lexical markers. For example, normally we do not put an accentuation on the *-o* in *chied-o scusa* to emphasise the subject, but we can do so with *io*. Considering that the pragmatic markedness of apologiser and apologisee expressed in a morphological way is different from cases where apologiser and apologisee were explicitly spelled out, we adopt two sets of terms to mark the distinction: 'Apologiser' and 'Morphological Apologiser'; and 'Apologisee' and 'Morphological Apologisee'. This terminological choice makes it possible to conduct a two-level analysis: the first level analysis can focus on functional elements that are explicitly expressed with lexical items, while the second level can gather richer syntactic details by considering elements that are expressed morphologically. In other words, at the second level, inflectional morphemes can be coded as supertags to provide more granular syntactic information. Moreover, this terminological specificity, which is absent from the terminological set designed for the local grammar of apology in English, contributes to highlighting the syntactic peculiarities that characterise the speech act of apology in Italian as a pro-drop language.

We then performed the local grammar analyses of apology in Italian. Our analyses appear to suggest that Apologising (which is primarily associated with regret-expressing) and Forgiveness-seeking (which is primarily associated with pardon-asking) are the two core elements of apology in Italian, which turn out to be constitutive of the speech act. In other words, the speech act of apology in Italian is mainly realised by one of the two elements. The use of a core element may be combined with other complementary functional elements in certain cases to carry out the act of apology.

Among the complementary elements, the elements that have a relatively close relationship with the core elements are Apologiser, Morphological Apologiser, Apologisee, Morphological Apologisee, and Specification. Although the term 'Apologiser' literally signals the subject who performs the act of apology, in Italian it is mostly represented by the pronominal clitic of *mi*, which takes the role of a direct/indirect object of a verb (e.g., *scusami, mi dispiace*). This grammatical status constructs the apologiser as a receiver of an action instead of an actor that makes an action. In English, on the other hand, Apologiser is often represented as the subject of a verb (e.g., *I* in *I'm sorry*) and assumes a higher level of activity.

The final two elements were more peripheral. One is 'Intensifier', which refers to linguistic elements that intensify the degree of regret or upgrade the sincerity of regret, and the other is 'Initiator' which involves recurrent discourse markers frequently co-occurring with apology in Italian. These are contrastive markers (*ma, però*) referring to discourse structure rather than to any incompatibility between propositions. They act as topic orientation markers or attention markers (Fraser, 2009a, 2009b), as they introduce an apology by signalling a change in topic and avoiding the abruptness of what follows.

Below we discuss in greater detail the local grammar analyses of apologies in Italian. Our analysis shows that, like apology in English, apology in Italian is also typically realised by idiomatic expressions such as *scusa*, *scusi,* etc. These forms can be simply labelled as "Forgiveness-seeking". If one intends to consider the morphological information embedded in them, they could be analysed as 'Forgiveness-seeking + Morphological Apologisee', or 'Morphological Apologiser + Forgiveness-seeking', as illustrated in Tables 5a and 5b.

In Tables 6 and 7, it is noted that the functional element of 'Forgiveness-seeking' is often paired with 'Apologiser' which is lexically expressed by the clitic pronoun *-mi*, indicating the presence of the individual who is seeking forgiveness. Due to the syntactic behaviour of clitics when used with verbs in imperative form, 'Apologiser' typically comes after 'Forgiveness-seeking' when the verb is used in informal imperative, while in formal situations, it is positioned before 'Forgiveness-seeking'.

[4] https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/apologize.

Table 5a
Apology construed as 'Forgiveness-seeking'.

| Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) |
|---|
| *Scusa.*'(You) excuse.' |

Table 5b
Apology construed as 'Forgiveness-seeking'.

| (Morphological Apologiser + ) Forgiveness-seeking |
|---|
| *Chiedo scusa.*'(I) ask pardon.' |

Table 6
Apology construed as 'Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser'.

| Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) | Apologiser |
|---|---|
| *Scusa-* 'Excuse | *-mi* me' |

Table 7
Apology construed as 'Apologiser + Forgiveness-seeking'.

| Apologiser | Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) |
|---|---|
| *Mi* 'Me | *scusi* excuse' |

In addition to 'Forgiveness-seeking', another constitutive element of the speech act of apology in Italian is 'Apologising', which explicitly expresses regret. This element is almost always accompanied by 'Apologiser', resulting in the typical pattern of 'Apologiser + Apologising'. This pattern is typically realised through expressions such as *mi dispiace* and *mi spiace* (Table 8), where the apologiser is represented as indirect object. In English, this action is typically realised through performative verbs that represent the apologiser as Subject (e.g., *I apologise*), or by an adjective that describes the mental status of the apologiser (e.g., *sorry*). This highlights that the lexico-grammatical resources available to realise one particular functional element may vary across languages (see subsection 4.4 for further discussion).

The two core elements, namely 'Forgiveness-seeking' and 'Apologising' (regret-expressing), can be elaborated by various optional elements. One noticeable optional element that emerges in our data is 'Initiator' (Tables 9, 10 and 11). In Italian, 'Initiator' is expressed through adversative markers such as *ma* 'but' and *però* 'however'. In general, *ma* is a pragmatic marker that is widely used with various linguistic units such as *scusa*, *guarda*, *dai* and so on (Fedriani and Molinelli, 2019). Bazzanella (2006: 451) has discussed the various functions of *ma*. It can be used as a contrastive connective to signal contrast at a semantic or pragmatic level (e.g., *poveri ma belli*, 'poor but beautiful'). Additionally, it can also function as a discourse marker, which does not necessarily relate to two contrasting semantic values, but instead to the speaker's speech act and its context. In our data, *ma* is often used as a discourse marker

Table 8
Apology construed as 'Apologiser + Apologising'.

| Apologiser | Apologising (i.e., regret-expressing) |
|---|---|
| *Mi* 'To me | *dispiace/spiace*(it) upsets' |

Table 9
Apology construed as 'Initiator + Forgiveness-seeking.

| Initiator | Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) |
|---|---|
| *Però* | *scusa* |
| 'But | excuse' |

Table 10
Apology construed as 'Initiator + Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser'.

| Initiator | Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) | Apologiser |
|---|---|---|
| *Ma* | *scusa-* | *-mi* |
| 'But | excuse | me' |

Table 11
Apology construed as 'Initiator + Apologiser + Apologising'.

| Initiator | Apologiser | Apologising |
|---|---|---|
| *Però* | *mi* | *dispiace* |
| 'But | to me | (it) upsets' |

introducing an apology so as to mitigate the potential impoliteness of a face threatening act (FTA) (Ghezzi and Molinelli, 2019). Consider, for example,

(1) *io // ho imparato da // da giulio anche eh dal mio suocero // si' anche mio padre // tuo papa' //* ***ma scusa****, tuo papà che lavoro faceva?*
'I // have learned from // from Giulio also eh from my father-in-law // yes also my father // your father // **but excuse me**, what job did your father do?'

Example (1) is a case in which the apology might be intended to mitigate the potential offence caused by a privacy-related question that could harm the negative face of the interlocutor or violate a general social norm (Tantucci, 2021).[5] This apology pattern, which uses the Initiator *ma*, serves to introduce a potential offence in a friendly conversation and can be considered as a 'face-saving' strategy. On the one hand, it draws the hearer's attention to the fact that there will be some change of topic in their dialogue. On the other hand, it functions as an *alerter* to 'warn' the hearer that the act that follows might be face-threatening (Fedriani and Molinelli, 2019).

As discussed in multiple studies, *ma* has also been considered a complex discourse marker (Bazzanella, 2006; Fedriani and Molinelli, 2019). In some cases, the apologetic formula *ma scusa* can be a marker of impoliteness when it is used to justify the face-threatening act that follows (Fedriani and Molinelli, 2019). Although *scusa* still maintains the inherent value of apology, the use of *ma* adds some interactional contrast (Fedriani and Molinelli, 2019). Occasionally, the Initiator *ma* is repeated (e.g., *ma scusa ma* 'but excuse me but') and the second *ma* serves to introduce the act that follows. In such cases, the potential impoliteness might be further enhanced.

Patterns that involve the element of 'Specification' (Tables 12, 13, 14, and 15) are cases where the reason or offence for an apology is clearly specified. In many cases of apology, the reason or offence for an apology is implicitly indicated. For instance, in Example (1), while the use of apology markers constructs the act of questioning as an offensive act, the question itself (i.e., *tuo papà che lavoro faceva?* 'what's your father's job?') is not an explicit direct reason for the apology. In this case, the question is not annotated as 'Specification'. In contrast, the examples shown in Tables 12–15 clearly indicate the reason why the apologiser is making an apology.

Another element that may arise in the pragmatic realisation of an apology is 'Apologisee', i.e., the offended party who receives the apology. The use of 'Apologisee' serves the purpose of drawing attention to the hearer and fostering famil-

[5] In the theory of intersubjectivity (Tantucci, 2021), this could be seen as extended intersubjectification of grammaticalised usages of *scusa*, in which case the addressee is no longer the single interlocutor but a general 3rd party in society.

Table 12
Apology construed as 'Forgiveness-seeking + Specification'.

| Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) | Specification |
|---|---|
| *Scusi* 'Excuse | *per questo* for this' |

Table 13
Apology construed as 'Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser + Specification'.

| Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) | Apologiser | Specification |
|---|---|---|
| *Scusa-* 'Excuse | *-mi* me | *sono nervosa* I'm nervous' |

Table 14
Apology construed as 'Apologiser + Apologising + Specification'.

| Apologiser | Apologising | Specification |
|---|---|---|
| *Mi* 'To me | *spiace*(it) upsets | *non lo accetto* I don't accept it" |

Table 15
Apology construed as 'Apologiser + Forgiveness-seeking + Specification'.

| Apologiser | Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) | Specification |
|---|---|---|
| *Mi* 'Me | *scusi* excuse | *tutte le bestialità* for all the brutality' |

iarity (Bazzanella, 1994). In our data, we identified five patterns that involve recipient of apologies (Tables 16–20). 'Apologisee' can appear before the core act of apology, as seen in patterns such as 'Apologisee + Forgiveness-seeking' (Table 16) and 'Apologisee + Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser' (Table 17), or it may come after the act of apology, as in patterns like 'Forgiveness-seeking + Apologisee' (Table 18), 'Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser + Apologisee' (Table 19) and 'Apologiser + Forgiveness-seeking + Apologisee' (Table 20). All of these patterns contain the essential functional element of 'Forgiveness-seeking'. Theoretically, 'Apologisee' can also be used in conjunction with 'Apologising', as in *Mi dispiace, Lina* 'I'm sorry, Lina". However, this combination was not observed in the KIPTO corpus. There are two reasons that may account for the absence of this pattern. First, the frequency of 'Apologising' in the KIPTO corpus is significantly lower than that of 'Forgiveness-seeking', as will be discussed in the following section. Second, this pattern typically expresses a higher level of empathy and is often used in situations involving severe offence. Given that the KIPTO corpus mainly comprises conversations, there is less need to specify the recipient of an apology.

The sincerity of the action of apologising or forgiveness-seeking can be intensified by adverbial complements such as *veramente* 'truly' and *un sacco* 'a lot'. These elements are labelled 'Intensifier'. Two common patterns involving 'Intensifier' are 'Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser + Intensifier' (Table 21) and 'Apologising + Apologising + Intensifier' (Table 22).

Table 16
Apology construed as 'Apologisee + Forgiveness-seeking'.

| Apologisee | Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologiser) |
|---|---|
| *Ti* 'To you | *chiedo scusa*(I) ask pardon' |

Table 17
Apology construed as 'Apologisee + Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser'.

| Apologisee | Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) | Apologiser |
|---|---|---|
| *Lina*<br>'Lina | *perdona-*<br>Pardon | *-mi*<br>me' |

Table 18
Apology construed as 'Forgiveness-seeking + Apologisee'.

| Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) | Apologisee |
|---|---|
| *Scusi*<br>'Pardon | *professore*<br>professor' |

Table 19
Apology construed as 'Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser + Apologisee'.

| Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) | Apologiser | Apologisee |
|---|---|---|
| *Perdona-*<br>'Pardon | *-mi*<br>Me | *Ale*<br>Ale' |

Table 20
Apology construed as 'Apologiser + Forgiveness-seeking + Apologisee'.

| Apologiser | Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) | Apologisee |
|---|---|---|
| *Mi*<br>'Me | *Perdoni*<br>Pardon | *signorina*<br>Miss' |

Table 21
Apology construed as 'Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser + Intensifier'.

| Forgiveness-seeking (+Morphological Apologisee) | Apologiser | Intensifier |
|---|---|---|
| *Scusa-*<br>'Pardon | *-mi*<br>Me | *veramente*<br>truly' |

Table 22
Apology construed as 'Apologiser + Apologising + Intensifier'.

| Apologiser | Apologising | Intensifier |
|---|---|---|
| *Mi*<br>'To me | *spiace*(it)<br>upsets | *un sacco*<br>a lot' |

Above we have discussed the local grammar analyses of apologies in the KIPTO corpus. As noted in Section 4.1, there are a few markers which can also be used to make apologies in Italian but did not occur in the KIPTO corpus, suggesting that these markers may not be frequently used in daily conversation. Nevertheless, our examination of instances co-occurring with such markers shows that they can also be analysed using the local grammar terminologies presented in Table 4. For instance, *mi scuso* '(I) excuse myself' can be analysed as 'Apologiser + Forgiveness-seeking'; *ti chiedo perdono* 'to you (I) ask pardon' as 'Apologisee + Forgiveness-seeking'; *sono spiacente* '(I) am sorry' as 'Apol-

Table 23
Distribution of apology patterns in the KIPTO corpus.

| No. | Pattern | Frequency | Percentage |
|---|---|---|---|
| PA* 1 | Forgiveness-seeking<br>e.g., *Scusa.* | 254 | 52.59% |
| PA 2 | Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser<br>e.g., *Scusami.* | 76 | 15.73% |
| PA 3 | Initiator + Forgiveness-seeking<br>e.g., *Ma scusa.* | 47 | 9.73% |
| PA 4 | Forgiveness-seeking + Specification<br>e.g., *Scusi per questo.* | 27 | 5.59% |
| PA 5 | Apologiser + Apologising<br>e.g., *Mi dispiace.* | 18 | 3.73% |
| PA 6 | Apologiser + Apologising + Specification<br>e.g., *Mi spiace non lo accetto.* | 16 | 3.31% |
| PA 7 | Apologiser + Forgiveness-seeking<br>e.g., *Mi scusi.* | 13 | 2.69% |
| PA 8 | Forgiveness-seeking + Apologisee<br>e.g., *Scusi professore.* | 13 | 2.69% |
| PA 9 | Initiator + Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser<br>e.g., *Ma scusami.* | 6 | 1.24% |
| PA 10 | Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser + Specification<br>e.g., *Scusami sono nervoso.* | 3 | 0.62% |
| PA 11 | Apologiser + Forgiveness-seeking + Apologisee<br>e.g., *Mi perdoni signorina.* | 2 | 0.41% |
| PA 12 | Initiator + Apologiser + Apologising<br>e.g., *Però mi dispiace.* | 2 | 0.41% |
| PA 13 | Apologiser + Forgiveness-seeking + Specification<br>e.g., *Mi scusi tutte le bestialità.* | 1 | 0.21% |
| PA 14 | Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser + Intensifier<br>e.g., *Scusami veramente.* | 1 | 0.21% |
| PA 15 | Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser + Apologisee<br>e.g., *Perdonami Ale.* | 1 | 0.21% |
| PA 16 | Apologisee + Forgiveness-seeking<br>e.g., *Ti chiedo scusa.* | 1 | 0.21% |
| PA 17 | Apologisee + Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser<br>e.g., *Lina perdonami.* | 1 | 0.21% |
| PA 18 | Apologiser + Apologising + Intensifier<br>e.g., *Mi spiace un sacco.* | 1 | 0.21% |
| Total | | 483 | |

* 'PA' here is the abbreviation of 'Pattern'.

ogising'. This indicates that the terminologies identified in the present study are generally useful for local grammar analyses of apologies in Italian.

### 4.3. Corpus analysis: Results and discussion

Based on the above analyses, we identified 18 local grammar patterns of apology in the KIPTO corpus, which were itemised in Table 23. As shown in the tables presented above, the elements of 'Morphological Apologiser' and 'Morphological Apologisee' are conventionally related to specific patterns. For the sake of readability, these two elements are not presented in Table 23. Their statistical status will be discussed when we examine each single functional element.

We are now in a position to discuss some observations that can be drawn from the analyses. Most notably, the analyses show the viability and applicability of local grammars in speech act studies in languages other than English (see also Su and Fu, 2023). With regard to apology in Italian, the study, firstly, indicates that the simple single-element pattern 'Forgiveness-seeking' is the primary core pattern, accounting for 52.59% of all the instances of apologies identified in the KIPTO corpus. This means that seeking forgiveness is the fundamental form for making apologies in Italian, suggesting that Italian speakers tend to prefer the strategy of seeking forgiveness rather than explicitly expressing regret when performing the speech act of apology. This prevalence of the forgiveness-seeking strategy over the strategy of

apologising or regret-expressing reinforces the observation made by Nuzzo (2007), who noted that Italian L1 speakers use more frequently the pardon-requesting strategy (equivalent to the strategy of forgiveness-seeking) than the regret-expressing strategy. In fact, the speech act itself in Italian is denominated 'scusarsi', with explicit reference to forgiveness-seeking.

Secondly, the analyses reveal that the pattern 'Forgiveness-seeking + Apologiser' (15.73%) is more prevalent than 'Apologiser + Forgiveness-seeking' (2.69%). The former employs informal imperatives, while the latter employs a formal imperative. This could be attributed to the fact that the data was drawn from a spoken corpus, where language tends to be informal and colloquial. Additionally, it may also depend upon the specific types of conversations where the occurrences are found, as the corpus encompasses a wide range of informal peer-to-peer communicative events, along with more formal situations. In other words, instances of apologies in the corpus were mostly characterised by an informal register.

Thirdly, the Initiator *ma* tends to accompany the strategy of forgiveness-seeking, but it rarely appears when expressing regret. Table 23 shows that the patterns 'Initiator + Forgiveness-seeking' (9.73%) and 'Initiator + Forgiveness-seek ing + Apologiser' (1.24%) accounts for 10.97% of the total occurrences, while the pattern 'Initiator + Apologiser + Apol ogising' accounts for only 0.41%. This suggests that the adversative 'Initiator' is much more frequently combined with 'Forgiveness-seeking' than with 'Apologising'. This may be related to the typical occurrence of the first pattern (*ma scusa(mi)*) with a mitigating function in preventive apologies.

Furthermore, Italian speakers tend to provide details about the offence when expressing regret, while this specification co-occurs less frequently with the strategy of forgiveness-seeking. This is supported by the fact that the pattern 'Apologiser + Apologising + Specification' is used in a quantitatively similar way (3.31%) to the pattern 'Apologiser + Apologising', whereas the pattern 'Forgiveness-seeking + Specification' (5.59%) is used much less frequently than 'Forgiveness-seeking' (52.59%).

Overall, among the local grammar patterns identified in the KIPTO corpus, the dominant one appears to be the single-element pattern 'Forgiveness-seeking' (PA 1), which accounts for 52.59% of all identified instances of apologies in the corpus. The majority of patterns contain two or three elements, while complex patterns such as *scusami tanto per il ritardo* 'Pardon me a lot for being late' are rare or even absent. As noted by Su and Wei (2018: 453), the complexity of an apology pattern is related to the severity of the offence (cf., Drew et al., 2016: 2) and the sincerity of the apology. Therefore, the results reveal that the KIPTO corpus, which contains conversation types such as lessons, office hours, interviews, exams, and spontaneous conversation, does not contain many instances of severe apology situations, or that apologies in the corpus are highly formulaic and may be regarded as tokens of apologies (see also Jucker, 2019).

Apart from identifying local grammar patterns, the analysis also offers valuable insights into the distribution of individual functional element. For instance, Table 24 displays the percentage of each functional element in the speech act of apology within the KIPTO corpus.

The examination of the distribution of these functional elements further leads to several observations. Firstly, forgiveness-seeking is a fundamental element in Italian apologies. As shown in Table 24, the term of 'Forgiveness-s eeking' (92.36%) is significantly more frequently used than 'Apologising', namely, regret-expressing (7.64%). In terms of interpersonal function, 'Forgiveness-seeking' is hearer-based, using imperative forms like *scusa* and *perdona* to seek forgiveness. In contrast, 'Apologising' is speaker-based, focusing on expressing the speaker's regret. This suggests that Italian apologies are primarily hearer-based, as the typical strategy of apologising is to employ imperative expressions to seek forgiveness from the hearer.

Table 24
Distribution of each functional term of apology in the KIPTO corpus.

| Functional element | Frequency | Percentage* |
|---|---|---|
| Forgiveness-seeking | 446 | 92.34% |
| Apologiser | 141 | 29.19% |
| Initiator | 55 | 11.39% |
| Specification | 47 | 9.73% |
| Apologising | 35 | 7.25% |
| Apologisee | 18 | 3.73% |
| Intensifier | 2 | 0.41% |
| Morphological Apologiser | 6 | 1.2% |
| Morphological Apologisee | 440 | 91.1% |
| **Total** | **483** | |

* Percentage = Frequency of the functional element/Total number of apology instances.

In terms of politeness strategies, the forgiveness seeking and regret-expressing may correspond to different types of politeness. The Italian culture tends to privilege positive politeness when making apologies by seeking forgiveness from the hearer, thus emphasising the speaker's positive face, i.e., "the want of every member that his wants be desirable to at least some others" (Brown and Levinson, 1987: 62). The lesser used strategy of regret-expressing, on the other hand, respects the interlocutors' negative face, which reflects "the want of every 'competent adult member' that his actions be unimpeded by others" (Brown and Levinson, 1987: 62). Another observation that is worth discussing in the data is that Italian speakers tend to not mention the offence or reason when apologising. The functional element of 'Specification' only accounts for 10.12% of all instances of apology. Consider, for example:

(2) ***Scusate*** *il ritardo.*

APOLOGISING + SPECIFICATION
'**Forgive** the being late.'.

(3) ***Scusami****, hai una penna?*

APOLOGISING.
'Excuse me, do you have a pen?'.

Example (2) explicitly specifies the offence that makes the interlocutor feel uncomfortable. Example (3), on the other hand, does not explicitly specify what the offence is, but is followed directly by a request that is implicitly interpreted by the speaker as an offence. If the speaker says *Scusami per il disturbo, hai una penna?* ('Excuse me for the inconvenience, do you have a pen?'), then the type of offence is specified explicitly. The data from the present study shows that in most of the cases of apology, Italian speakers do not explicitly specify the offence or the reason, which is also likely to due to the spoken nature of the KIPTO corpus.

Furthermore, the functional elements 'Apologisee' (3.72%) and 'Intensifier' (0.41%) are poorly represented in the sample. These two functional elements can contribute to the sincerity of apology to some extent. 'Intensifier' reinforces the speaker's concern regarding the act of apology, while the use of 'Apologisee' can contribute to enhancing the familiarity between the interlocutors (Bazzanella, 1994). For example, in comparison to simply saying *mi scusi* 'pardon me', it would be pragmatically more explicit to use the expression *mi scusi, professore* 'pardon me, professor' by calling the attention of the hearer. However, it seems that in the Italian sample most instances of apology were not used for serious offences and, therefore, the degree of explicitness is relatively low.

### *4.4. Apologies in Italian and English: A local-grammar-based cross-linguistic comparison*

Based on the previous analyses, in this section we further discuss apologies in Italian and English from a cross-linguistic perspective, specifically by comparing the local grammar of apology developed in each (Su, 2020, 2021; Su and Wei, 2018). Our aim is to show that one notable value of employing local grammars to speech act studies is that such investigation could offer a viable method for cross-linguistic studies on speech acts. The idea is that the local grammar patterns not only connect the level of the lexico-grammar to that of the pragmatic function, but at the same time also enable cross-linguistic or cross-cultural comparison, much in the same way as when looking at a speech act diachronically, historical pragmatics needs to identify the basic properties of the nature of a speech act that stay the same or change across time periods (Jucker, 2019; Jucker and Taavitsainen, 2000).

On the basis of the data from (Su, 2021: 425–426) local grammar analyses of apology in spoken British English, we calculated the percentage of each functional element in all the instances of apology (Table 25).

Table 25
Distribution of each functional term of apology in the Spoken BNC2014 corpus (adapted from Su, 2021).

| Functional element | Example | Frequency | Percentage |
|---|---|---|---|
| Apologising | *Sorry* | 5186 | 84.59% |
| Apologiser | ***I****'m sorry* | 1062 | 17.32% |
| Forgiveness-seeking | ***Forgive*** *me* | 811 | 13.23% |
| Specification | *Sorry* ***for saying that*** | 788 | 12.85% |
| Apologisee | *Sorry,* ***guys*** | 284 | 4.63% |
| Intensifier | *I'm* ***terribly*** *sorry* | 226 | 3.69% |
| **Total** | | **6131** | |

The data presented in Tables 24 and 25 suggest both cross-linguistic similarities and differences in terms of distribution of local grammar elements. One significant difference is related to the use of core elements in apologies. Specifically, Italian apologies prioritise the positive politeness form of 'Forgiveness-seeking' (92.34%), while apologies in British English prioritise the negative politeness form of 'Apologising', i.e., regret-expressing (84.59%).

This finding reveals an essential pragmatic difference between the Italian and British cultures. Positive politeness, which is defined as an "extension of intimacy, to imply common ground or sharing of wants" (Brown and Levinson, 1987: 103), tends to be connected with low social distance, which often characterises collectivist cultures. The relation between politeness pattern and cultural pattern has been discussed by Ogiermann's study of apologising in British English, Polish and Russian (Ogiermann, 2009). She noted that the dominant focus on the expression of regret in English, as a form of negative politeness, can be ascribed to the individualism that characterises the British culture. The noticeable use of forgiveness-seeking in Polish and Russian, on the other hand, instantiates the presence of positive politeness in Slavic cultures, which are characterised by collectivism and relatively low social distance (Ogiermann, 2009).

According to Hofstede, Hofstede, and Minkov (2010), the degree of individualism is high in Great Britian, low in Poland and Russia, while Italy sits in-between. The data in the present study conforms to Ogiermann's (2009) analytical framework that associates apology politeness strategies to cultural types. Italian culture, which is less marked by individualism than British culture (Hofstede, Hofstede, and Minkov, 2010), prioritises the positive politeness form of apology, while apologies in British English are noticeably characterised by negative politeness. An awareness of cross-cultural variations in the use of politeness strategies is particularly important for cross-cultural communication: the expression of regret might even be considered as reluctant, superficial and even insincere in positive politeness cultures such as the Russian and Polish cultures (Ogiermann, 2009).

In comparison to the core elements in apologies, optional elements, such as 'Specification' (9.73% in Italian, 12.85% in English), 'Apologisee' (3.73% in Italian, 4.63% in English), 'Apologiser' (29.19 in Italian, 17.32% in English) and 'Intensifier' (0.41% in Italian, 3.69% in English), have a relatively low proportion in both the Italian and English corpus. Although in Italian the element of 'Morphological Apologisee' has a rather high frequency, it is inherently linked to conventional expressions such as *scusa* and *scusi.* This suggests that speakers of both languages nowadays prefer simple and formulaic ways for making apologies. On the other hand, the instances of apology retrieved from the corpora do not seem to refer to particularly serious reasons for apologising that would require more elaborate forms.

In terms of types of functional elements, Italian is by and large similar to English (Su and Wei, 2018: 447). One particular difference concerns the adversative element of 'Initiator', which characterises Italian apology but is absent in the local grammar of apology in English (Su and Wei, 2018: 447). The present study shows that adversative conjunctions such as *ma* 'but' and *però* 'but' are frequently present in the Italian data (e.g., ***ma*** *scusa*). These high-frequency elements serve to introduce the act of apology and are labelled as 'Initiator'.

This leads to an important difference between Italian and English apologies: although *but* is semantically equivalent to *ma,* they are not pragmatically equivalent. In Italian, *ma* is a discourse marker frequently used with the act of apology. In English, on the other hand, no such regular association has been noticed, while for example frequent co-occurrence of apology with *oops, haa* has been examined as illocutionary force indicating devices of apology (Aijmer, 2019; Lutzky and Kehoe, 2017).

To summarise, this section has explored the possibility of analysing apologies in Italian from a local grammar perspective and has demonstrated how this approach can enhance our comprehension of the lexico-grammatical realisations of apologies (and likely other speech acts) in Italian. We have also discussed the similarities and differences that emerge from the local grammar analyses of apologies between Italian and English, highlighting the value of local grammars in cross-linguistic speech act studies.

## 5. OPPORTUNITIES AND CHALLENGES

In Section 4 we presented a local grammar of apology in Italian. In this section, we further discuss the opportunities and challenges of extending the local grammar approach to account for speech acts in various languages. Firstly, this study provides a systematic and coherent description of the speech act of apology in Italian, gathering some evidence to show the possibility and feasibility of developing local grammars of speech acts in languages other than English (see also Su and Fu, 2023). The feasibility of applying a local grammar approach to various languages lies in the fact that speech acts, which though may vary across languages, are universal phenomena.

Secondly, findings of local grammars of speech acts in various languages provide a foundation for cross-linguistic or cross-cultural studies on speech acts. In general, apology is regarded as an act of negative politeness (Brown and Levinson, 1987). While this view is by and large valid for English, it might not be applicable to apology in other languages and cultures. By deconstructing the speech act of apology in minor pragmatic components that are comparable across languages, the local grammar approach used in this study has provided fresh insights into the culture-specificity

of apologies. It has unveiled the different politeness patterns used in Italian and English, suggesting that apology in Italian tends to emphasise positive face rather than negative face, as has been discussed in detail in subsection 4.4.

At the same time, applying local grammars to account for speech acts in other languages may face many challenges. One primary challenge pertains to the availability of corpus resources. In English, the analysis of speech acts using local grammars is aided by the existence of extensive corpora, such as Spoken BNC1994 and Spoken BNC2014. However, corpus resources in other languages are often limited. Taking Italian for example, there have only been very few large and representative corpora that are currently available to the public, which poses a challenge to develop local grammars of speech acts in Italian. Nonetheless, the KIPTO corpus used in the present study could be one useful resource for this line of research.

Moreover, the comparability of corpora from different languages in cross-linguistic speech act studies must be considered. Such corpora may have been compiled according to entirely different criteria or in contexts with different sociolinguistic elements. Italian corpora of the kind we have used may, for example, tend to be largely dominated by intracultural communication, whereas English corpora may feature a higher percentage of intercultural encounters when academic interactions are concerned.

A further challenge is the identification and retrieval of instances associated with a given speech act, which is a fundamental step for local grammar analysis. Adolphs (2008: 9) notes that "[o]ne of the main obstacles in analysing utterances' function using a corpus-based approach is that we can search a corpus only for language forms, not for function". Although it is possible to identify a list of lexical forms which were typically associated with a given speech act in a language, it is still unlikely that the list can be exhaustive, even with the aid of generative artifical intelligence. The local grammar patterns of a speech act revealed by a corpus-based approach, therefore, include only those patterns that were realised by instances of the pre-determined list of markers. Losing sight of the diversity of underrepresented linguistic expressions is one limitation that the corpus-based local grammar approach needs to address in future research.

Finally, another challenge that is raised in the present study relates to the identification of local grammar terminologies that can be used to analyse a specific speech act. Previous studies have suggested guiding principles for local grammar analysis in English (e.g., Su, 2020). When analysing another language, however, one should adapt the way of component labelling according to the grammatical system, which may vary across languages. In particular, one should decide if and how to label a specific set of syntactic units of a language. Let us take the morphology of Italian as an example. Unlike English, the Italian grammatical system is characterised by verb conjugation, which allows the absence of the subject of a verb, as discussed in Section 4.1. Whether to label a morphological unit as a functional element should depend on the research design. In this study, we have decided to use the labels of 'Morphological Apologiser' and 'Morphological Apologisee' to distinguish them from 'Apologiser' and 'Apologisee' that are realised by individual lexical items. This has helped us to be conscious of the syntactic and pragmatic differences when comparing the local grammar data of Italian with those of English.

## 6. CONCLUSIONS

The aim of this paper has been to explore the feasibility of applying local grammars to speech act studies in and across various languages. To that end, this study developed a local grammar of apology in Italian, which shows that local grammars can be effectively applied to explore how Italian apologies are constructed. This in turn highlights the potential value of using the local grammar approach to analyse various speech acts in and across languages. We have also discussed the opportunities and challenges associated with applying this alternative approach to speech act studies. On the one hand, opportunities include the feasibility of extending the local grammar approach to account for speech acts in various languages, thereby offering a viable approach to cross-linguistic and/or cross-cultural speech act studies. On the other hand, the main challenges include the availability of relatively large and representative corpora of a given language, retrieval of speech act instances in naturally occurring texts, and the identification of local grammar terminologies. Overall, the present study, together with previous ones that developed local grammars of speech acts in English and Chinese, should have provided compelling evidence to show that local grammars can be a valid and viable approach for documenting and describing speech acts in various languages, which also has important implications for cross-linguistic and/or cross-cultural speech act studies (e.g., Su and Fu, 2023). We would thus look forward to more research that employs the local grammar approach to speech act studies in the future and we believe such research could help take forward this research area.

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## CREDIT AUTHORSHIP CONTRIBUTION STATEMENT

**Danni Yu:** Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. **Hang Su:** Conceptualization, Funding acquisition, Project administration, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. **Marina Bondi:** Formal analysis, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

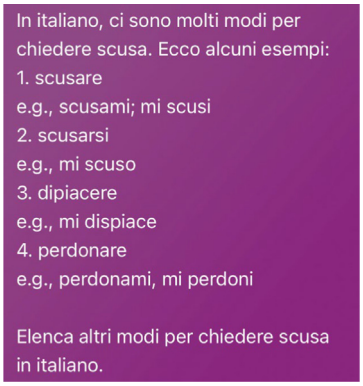
## Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

## Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

## APPENDIX 1. THE PROMPT USED TO RETRIEVE APOLOGY EXPRESSIONS ON BING CHATBOT AND AN EXAMPLE OF THE OUTPUTS



Ciao, questo è Bing. Sono felice di parlare con te in italiano. 😊

Hai elencato alcuni modi molto comuni per chiedere scusa in italiano. Ce ne sono altri che puoi usare in diverse situazioni. Ecco alcuni esempi:

5. pentirsi e.g., mi pento di aver fatto questo
6. chiedere venia e.g., chiedo venia per il mio comportamento
7. essere spiacente e.g., sono spiacente per il disagio
8. essere dispiaciuto e.g., sono dispiaciuto per la tua perdita
9. essere amareggiato e.g., sono amareggiato per l'accaduto
10. essere mortificato e.g., sono mortificato per il mio errore

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